

Dinner on Autopilot

What you'll build: a weekly meal plan and one grocery list — made in less time than it takes to preheat the oven.

"What's for dinner?" is the question that never stops. This lesson doesn't make it stop either — but it makes answering it take 5 minutes on Sunday instead of 30 stressful minutes every night.

The steps

1 Start with the fridge dump

Tonight's problem first. Open your fridge, tell Claude what you see:

COPY THIS PROMPT Here's what I have: [list what's in your fridge and pantry — rough is fine]. Give me 3 dinner ideas I can make in under 30 minutes using mostly this. My kids are [ages].

2 Then the weekly plan

This is the big one. Change the details to fit your family:

COPY THIS PROMPT Plan 5 weeknight dinners for a family of 4. One kid won't eat anything spicy. We're busy Tuesday, so that night needs to be 15 minutes max. Keep it budget-friendly. Then make me ONE grocery list for the whole week, sorted by store section.

Don't like Wednesday? Say *"swap Wednesday for something with pasta."* The list updates too.

3 Make it a Sunday habit

Save your weekly prompt somewhere handy (Notes app works). Every Sunday: paste, tweak, done. After a few weeks, tell Claude what your family actually ate and loved — the plans get smarter.

Make it yours

- **"Make Monday a slow-cooker meal I can start at 8am."**
- **"We had chicken tonight and there's a lot left. What can tomorrow's dinner be?"**
- **"Give me a 2-week rotation so we're not eating tacos every Tuesday forever."**

Real talk: the plan only works if it matches your actual life. Tell Claude the truth — the picky eater, the budget, the night you get home at 6:45. The more honest the prompt, the better the week.

That's the whole lesson. One question, answered for the whole week.